

What else to watch: *Platoon* (1986) ■ *The Battle of Algiers* (1966, pp.182–87) ■ *Black Hawk Down* (2001) ■ *Green Zone* (2010) ■ *Zero Dark Thirty* (2012)

Bigelow's movie won Academy Awards for Best Movie and Best Director. It was the lowest-grossing movie ever to win Best Picture.

sympathetically on the dilemmas and mental states of the three main characters. In doing so she in fact creates an anti-war movie more powerful than others.

Addicted to war

The Hurt Locker opens with a quotation by US journalist Chris Hedges from his book *War is a Force That Gives Us Meaning*: "The rush of battle is a potent and often lethal addiction, for war is a drug."

The Hurt Locker shows how this addiction affects the human psyche. The narrative follows the three men through their year's tour of duty, as they deal with unexploded bombs, snipers, and civilians used as bomb



carriers. Their commander is battle-hardened maverick Sergeant William James (Jeremy Renner). His team, Sergeant Sanborn (Anthony Mackie) and Specialist Owen Eldridge (Brian Geraghty), become so concerned by James's recklessness when he

acts without waiting for the bomb disposal robot and without wearing his protective suit, that they discuss killing him before he gets all three of them blown up. Yet, interestingly, they also seem to admire his craziness, and understand what is driving it. The adrenaline of his death wish makes him feel alive. After a failed attempt to remove a bomb vest from an Iraqi civilian, Sanborn begins to unravel psychologically, admitting that he cannot cope with the stress. Once home in the US, James, on the other hand, does not cope with real life. He feels that his purpose is to be in the conflict zone, where the perpetual danger made his life meaningful.

The movie drew criticism for focusing on a bomb disposal unit: soldiers without the troubling duty of killing anyone on screen. Most, however, praised Bigelow's feat in putting the viewer inside the "hurt locker"—a psychological prison of pain that comes from constantly being near explosions. ■



Kathryn Bigelow
Director

With *The Hurt Locker*, Kathryn Bigelow became the first woman to win the Oscar for Best Director. Born in California in 1951, she began making movies even before graduating from Columbia University, with a short called *The Set-Up* (1987). Soon she was making action movies with *Blue Steel* (1989), *Point Break* (1991), and science fiction *Strange Days* (1995). Her next movie, *K-19: The Widowmaker* (2002), was a submarine thriller. Oscar success came with *The Hurt Locker*, based on reportage of the Iraq War. Her movie about the hunt for Osama Bin Laden, *Zero Dark Thirty* (2012) was acclaimed but also attacked for what critics saw as an apparent endorsement of torture.

Key movies

1991 *Point Break*
2008 *The Hurt Locker*
2012 *Zero Dark Thirty*

“As you **get older**, some of the things **you love** might not seem **so special** anymore.”

Sergeant William James / *The Hurt Locker*

